



# Memoirs in Motion

A holiday abroad, the sights, the sounds, the atmosphere...whether you want to preserve the moments, or show off to less fortunate friends, a camcorder is something you just can't afford *not* to buy.

Michael Browne

Let's face it. Digital cameras are for capturing the moment, but we live our lives in motion, not in stills. A video gives that much-needed extra dimension to a memory..

Things have changed a lot from the bulky VHS camcorders that needed a professional touch to operate. The biggest hurdle to acceptance of any device is usability and, of course, pricing—especially in India. Camcorders are *there* as far as both these points go—you'll therefore see a lot of them in malls, showrooms and such.

## Canon DC230

### The Biggest Brother Syndrome

Following the same colour combination as the Canon DC210, the DC230 even has the same bright blue sticker showcasing the 35x optical zoom, and the On/Off button is located very conveniently—and works mighty well. We really like the idea of placing the 5-way joystick at the rear, where it is right under your eye—you can access it one-handed quite easily. The Auto/Programmed mode select button is right on top and very visible—in fact, everything feels so easily accessible and transparent. Once again, the detailed menu on the DC51 makes another appearance—lots of settings to tinker with—but it's all very easy to get into, and you'll never feel intimidated by the sheer number of options available.

The LCD viewfinder is widescreen (16:9) and quite clear—in fact, a pleasure to work with, overshadowed only by the LCD viewfinders on the Panasonic models.

The slightly higher specifications don't really make a difference to the DC230 as far as distinguishing it from the DC210 goes. The IS system works identically, which is to say, *not* satisfactorily. Outdoor shooting was a real joy with the DC230, and such videos really come to life—you won't know the lack of a 3 CCD sensor. Once again, the issue with indoor shooting rears its ugly head:

They're smaller (palm-sized or thereabouts), idiot-proof to use, offer stunning results, and cost much less than they did a year ago.

When people ask us if they can use a digital camera as a decent camcorder and quote our favourite word *convergence* as a reason, we don't bat an eyelid when rejoining: "Cameras are for still images; they dabble with video, that's all. You want photos—get a camera, videos—get a camcorder." And if you want both, buy one of each...

We've selected ten of the most widely-available models in our markets and brought them together for the first time.



the same noise was noticeable—the DC51 did much better than both its cheaper siblings.

At Rs 24,995, the DC230 performs very similarly to the DC210—we'd figure a positive difference of around 10 per cent. There's nothing other than its on-paper specs to justify shelling out six thousand rupees more. If you don't mind a cheaper Canon camcorder, buy the DC210 and save some cash.

#### Specifications

1 / 6-inch CCD sensor (1.07 megapixels); 2.7-inch LCD viewfinder (123,000 pixels); Digital (Electronic) Image Stabilisation; Weight: 405 gm

#### RATINGS OUT OF 10

|                          |       |
|--------------------------|-------|
| Menu/OSD Usability       | : 7.5 |
| Ergonomics               | : 7   |
| IS effectiveness         | : 6   |
| Video Quality (Indoors)  | : 6   |
| Video Quality (Outdoors) | : 8   |
| Photo Quality            | : 5.5 |
| Audio Quality            | : 7   |



#### How We Tested

| Parameters               | What We Looked At                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Menu/OSD Usability       | The intuitivity of the menu, its logical structure, how difficult individual features were to find                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Ergonomics               | The feel of the camcorders buttons, their location on the body and how easy it is to access them during use, how conducive button layout is to one-handed operation                                                                                                                 |
| IS effectiveness         | At the long end of the zoom, focusing on on-screen and on-paper text, watching for clarity. Zooming in on certain objects and watching for jitter—normal hand shake is omnipresent, but the finer, sudden little shakes should be absent if the IS system is doing its job properly |
| Video Quality (Indoors)  | Shooting in our test labs, focusing on various objects to ascertain clarity, speed of lens focussing, presence of casts under artificial lighting, and, of course, noise                                                                                                            |
| Video Quality (Outdoors) | How quickly the lens adapts to sudden changes on brightness, as in changing focus from a well-lit object to a dimly-lit one. Overall clarity and detail while zooming in on distant moving objects like vehicles                                                                    |
| Photo Quality            | A still image of the dial of a watch, studying the image for noise, casts, image resolution, clarity, blur, and colour rendition                                                                                                                                                    |
| Audio quality            | Indoors and outdoors. Indoors, how well the ambient sounds away from the recording were isolated; outdoors, how well wind noise was kept to a minimum                                                                                                                               |



## Sony DCR-DVD608E

### Vaio! Vot Style!

Sony's been known to make some gorgeous-looking products (read Vaio), and frankly, while the DCR-DVD608E didn't disappoint, we expected more. Ergonomics are good, though, and everything feels convenient and easy to reach during regular operation.

Juice is provided by an Info Lithium-ion battery, and your viewfinder actually displays how much power remains and how many hours of shooting time is left—at the touch of a button, even when the camcorder is powered off. Both video and still image shooting buttons feel very comfortable to use, and there are no ergonomic issues, at least with largish hands.

Sony's LCD viewfinder is good, crisp and clear—something we've come to expect from all their products—but not as good as the LCD on the Panasonic SDR-H20. It's a touchscreen, however—a nifty add-on and a definite plus for usability. There's also a night shot switch (On/Off). The menus are very well-laid-out and intuitive, particularly since each option has a small, one-line explanation that improves usability greatly, especially for newbies.

Sony uses a digital IS system that works reasonably well; however, it isn't comparable to the excellent optical IS system employed by Panasonic

on the SDR-H20, which remains the benchmark for the way IS systems should work as far as we're concerned.

The DCR-DVD608E gave us pretty good results with after-dark shooting. Audio quality was rather good, and the noise caused by wind atop a terrace (for example) will hardly be noticeable.

At Rs 19,990, the Sony DCR-DVD608E makes a strong statement for itself. It's got that remarkable sense of style, performs well especially considering the price, and makes a really good buy if you have 20-odd grand for a camcorder.

#### Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD image sensor (0.8 megapixel); LCD viewfinder 2.5-inches (123,000 pixels); Weight: 390 gm

#### RATINGS OUT OF 10

|                          |       |
|--------------------------|-------|
| Menu/OSD Usability       | : 7.5 |
| Ergonomics               | : 7.5 |
| IS effectiveness         | : 7   |
| Video Quality (Indoors)  | : 7   |
| Video Quality (Outdoors) | : 7.5 |
| Photo Quality            | : 6.5 |
| Audio quality            | : 7.5 |